LCQ2: Operation of GREEN@COMMUNITY GO

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Following is a question by the Hon Julia Lau and a reply by the Under Secretary for Environment and Ecology, Miss Diane Wong, in the Legislative Council today (July 8):

Question:

In early 2013, the Government announced the development of five pilot Community Green Stations in different parts of the territory, which were officially named GREEN@COMMUNITY in mid-2014, to promote environmental/green education and to enhance the collection network of recyclables. Currently, there are 12 Recycling Stations, 82 Recycling Stores and around 600 Recycling Spots, as well as over 100 sets of smart recycling bins, across the territory. In this connection, will the Government inform this Council:

(1) of the Government's annual provision for the GREEN@COMMUNITY project in each of the past three financial years; the actual operating expenditure, and the percentage of rental expenses therein; and

(2) given that in its reply to a question raised by a Member of this Council on April 30 last year, the Government indicated that the Environmental Protection Department was reviewing the tender arrangements and requirements for GREEN@COMMUNITY facilities, for example, by introducing different types of operators for Recycling Stores to reduce costs through enhanced competition; relocating some Recycling Stores to suitable government facilities and making greater use of smart recycling devices to gradually transform the operation of Recycling Stores into self-service recycling facilities, so as to reduce the rental expenses and operating costs, of the relevant progress?

Reply:

President,

Since its establishment, the community recycling network GREEN@COMMUNITY has shouldered the mission of fostering a waste reduction atmosphere, promoting a green lifestyle, and strengthening environmental education. It is dedicated to cultivating public awareness of environmental protection and encouraging sustainable lifestyles to take root within the community.

In 2015, the Environmental Protection Department (EPD) launched the Recycling Stations project, operating fixed community recycling centres to serve as regional hubs, and promote environmental protection through educational activities. Since 2020, the EPD has progressively set up (i) Recycling Stores, operating at fixed locations across 18 districts in Hong Kong; (ii) Recycling Spots, using street booths operating at regular schedules and locations to serve areas without fixed recycling facilities; and (iii) smart recycling bins, which not only facilitate self-service recycling for the public but also enable more efficient planning of recyclable collection services. By reaching into Public Rental Housing (PRH) Estates and clusters of single-block building, we provide convenient and efficient recycling services for the general public. Our service focus has gradually evolved from education and outreach to popularisation. At present, the GREEN@COMMUNITY network has expanded to over 800 collection points, comprising 12 Recycling Stations, 82 Recycling Stores, around 600 Recycling Spots, and over 140 sets of smart recycling bins.

To achieve the goal of "Zero Landfill" by 2035 as planned and to continue promoting waste reduction at source, the Government is taking forward a five-year waste reduction and recycling plan. This plan includes the progressive upgrading and transformation of GREEN@COMMUNITY to ensure that the recycling system, with GREEN@COMMUNITY as its backbone, is more user-friendly and cost-effective.

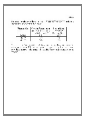
My reply to the question raised by the Hon Julia Lau is as follows:

(1) Operational expenditure and share of rental expenses in the past three financial years

The operation of GREEN@COMMUNITY facilities is funded by the Government, involving various expenses including the procurement and installation of recycling equipment, maintenance and repair, collection and transport of recyclables, incentives (such as gifts or GREEN$ points) to encourage public participation in recycling, and educational and promotional activities.

The amount of recyclables collected by GREEN@COMMUNITY increased from about 27 000 tonnes in 2023 to about 47 500 tonnes in 2025, an increase of over 75 per cent. This reflects that the expansion of facilities has effectively enhanced the coverage and effectiveness of recycling services.

Attachment



Annex

Furthermore, 50 Recycling Stores in PRH estates have been progressively commencing services since the second quarter of 2023. Meanwhile, to enhance the overall cost-effectiveness of GREEN@COMMUNITY operations, the EPD has been gradually relocating some Recycling Stores to government facilities. These measures have led to a year-on-year decrease in the share of rental expenses for the relevant facilities.

The EPD disburses operating fees to the operators of the GREEN@COMMUNITY facilities based on the services provided, operational performance, and the actual amount of recyclables handled. The operating expenditures of the GREEN@COMMUNITY project were $313 million in 2023-24 and $480 million in 2025-26. Over the same period, the share of rental expenses (only applicable to Recycling Stores) decreased from 21 per cent to 11 per cent. Details are set out in the Annex.

(2) Tendering arrangements, rental costs and enhancement of service models

The EPD has reviewed and finalised the tendering arrangements and requirements for GREEN@COMMUNITY, and has implemented various measures to enhance competition and reduce costs, with a view to using public resources more efficiently while expanding recycling services. The measures mainly focus on three aspects: (i) introducing competition and refining contract models; (ii) relocating to government facilities to reduce rental expenses; and (iii) extending service hours and promoting self-service recycling.

Introducing competition and refining contract models

In terms of contract arrangements, the EPD, for the first time, allowed private enterprises to participate in the bidding for the contracts of 12 Recycling Stores in early 2025. The market response was very enthusiastic, with over 60 bids received. The operating expenditure of these contracts was on average about 20 per cent lower than that of the previous contracts awarded between 2021 and 2022, demonstrating that introducing competition can effectively reduce operating costs.

In November 2025, the EPD consolidated 22 contracts for the 50 PRH estate Recycling Stores into 14 contracts. Through regional synergy and the sharing of backend workshops, the operating expenditure of these new contracts is expected to be on average about 30 per cent lower than that of the previous contracts awarded between 2023 and 2024.

Relocating to government facilities to reduce rental expenses

In terms of reducing rental expenses, the EPD has been actively relocating some Recycling Stores to government facilities with higher patronage. For example, GREEN@ABERDEEN in the Southern District was relocated to Aberdeen Market in May 2023. GREEN@HUNG SHUI KIU in Yuen Long District and GREEN@LUEN WO HUI in the North District were relocated to Hung Shui Kiu Environmental Hygiene Complex and Luen Wo Hui Market for operation in September and December 2025 respectively. GREEN@ON YU locating in On Yu Road Environmental Hygiene Complex in Sai Kung, is expected to commence operation within 2026. It will also provide storage space for Recycling Stores nearby, thereby reducing the need to rent additional workshops.

Extending service hours and promoting self-service recycling

In terms of service models, the daily service hours of all Recycling Stores have been extended from 10 hours to 13 hours. The extended service hours make it more convenient for working citizens to participate in recycling. In addition, self-service time slots have been introduced to reduce manpower requirements and enhance operational efficiency.

Five-year waste reduction and recycling plan: district-based consolidation and smart transformation

With the continued expansion of recycling facilities and investment of resources, recycling services need to move towards smart and systematic upgrading. To this end, the Government has launched a five-year waste reduction and recycling plan in this financial year. This includes the phased conversion of all 82 Recycling Stores into 24-hour self-service smart recycling facilities. The first 24-hour self-service smart Recycling Store is expected to commence operation in the third quarter of 2026 to test the operation workflow, collect operational data and gain experience. The smart transformation of the remaining Recycling Stores is expected to be progressively completed within 2027.

Meanwhile, the EPD will, based on the situation across 18 districts, consolidate the GREEN@COMMUNITY facilities currently operated by different organisations into district-based community recycling networks, with a single operator responsible for the operation of all recycling points, door-to-door collection services and logistics arrangements within each district. This will create economies of scale, enhancing overall operational efficiency and cost-effectiveness. We are currently preparing the relevant tender documents.

In addition, the EPD plans to progressively expand the deployment of smart recycling bins to more PRH and private housing estates, making recycling more convenient for the public. We will also leverage information technology and big data analytics to develop a more efficient smart recycling logistics system, optimising operations and logistics processes, further reducing costs, and establishing a more efficient

community recycling network for Hong Kong.

Thank you, President.

Ends/Wednesday, July 8, 2026
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